

Sieges

Not strictly a battle, a siege is a military blockade of a city or fortress. The aim is to conquer the city by waiting for those inside to surrender. Sometimes, the side laying siege attacks to speed things up.

1 Siege of Carthage 149–146 BCE
One of the longest sieges in history. The Romans surrounded Carthage (in modern Tunisia) and waited 3 years for its surrender, then enslaved the Carthaginian population.

2 Capture of Jerusalem, 1099
During the Crusader wars between Christians and Muslims, the Muslim defenders of Jerusalem lost control when the Christians built two enormous siege engines (towers on wheels) and scaled the walls.

Austerlitz, 1805

With smaller forces, the French Empire crushed Russia and Austria. One of Napoleon's greatest victories.

Actium, 31 BCE

Rome declared war on Antony and Cleopatra of Egypt. The Roman victory led to the beginning of the Roman Empire.

Thermopylae, 480 BCE

Vastly outnumbered Greek forces held the Persian Emperor Xerxes at bay for a vital 3 days.

Stalingrad, 1942–43

Long siege of this Soviet city caused immense suffering on both sides and eventually led to crippling defeat for Nazi Germany.

Fall of Constantinople, 1453

After a 4-month siege, Byzantine Empire fell to the invading Ottoman Empire.

Badger Mouth, 1211

Mongol ruler Genghis Khan's victory over the Jin Dynasty of China. One of history's bloodiest battles.

Huai-Hai, 1948

Final major fight in Chinese Civil War that led to the Communist takeover of China.

Battle of Inchon, 1950

A clear victory for the United Nations against North Korean forces in the Korean War.

Iwo Jima, 1945

The US captured this island as a way of possibly invading Japan. More than 21,000 Japanese died.

Wuhan, 1938

Soviet and revolutionary Chinese forces totaling 1,100,000 troops and 200 aircraft failed to stop Japan from capturing the city.

Dien Bien Phu, 1954

Viet Minh communist revolutionaries besieged and defeated the French to end the First Indochina War. The next year began another 20 years of fighting in Vietnam.

Omdurman, 1898

Small British and Egyptian forces massacred a huge, but ill-equipped, Sudanese Army.

El Alamein, 1942

Major tank battle of World War II. British-led victory over Axis Powers (Italy and Germany).

Kalinga, 262–261 BCE

The Mauryan Empire under Ashoka the Great fought the republic of Kalinga. At least 100,000 Kalingans were killed.

Isandlwana, 1879

Crushing victory for the Zulu nation over the British, despite relying mainly on spears and cowhide shields.

Surabaya, 1945

Heaviest battle of the Indonesian Revolution against the British and Dutch. Celebrated as Heroes' Day in Indonesia.

Coral Sea, 1942

World War II naval battle between Japan and the US and Australia. The battle was the first time aircraft carriers engaged each other.

Battlegrounds

At one time, armies met in formation on a single field of battle and fought for one to several days. By the 20th century, long-range weapons had changed warfare. Battlefields in places became theaters of war the size of countries.